

Republican Party was growing, while across the Atlantic Britain and France were showing disturbing signs of moving toward a quick recognition of Confederate independence. All of these factors, along with Lincoln's own predisposition against slavery, obliged the president to act decisively—he had, after all, run for the White House in 1860 on a platform devoted to restricting the institution's spread into the territories.

Federal generals had already flirted with emancipation in various different locations, which posed a threat to the political effect and long-term moral value of a presidentially issued policy. In August 1861, Union General John C. Frémont tried to emancipate all enslaved people in Missouri by a simple military declaration. In May 1862, General David Hunter did the same for those of Florida, Georgia, and South Carolina.

ARTICLE II, SECTION 2 The clause in the U.S. Constitution, under which Lincoln issued the Emancipation Proclamation, using his authority as commander-in-chief of the U.S. Army and Navy.